Poem: Poppies

Three days before Armistice Sunday
and poppies had already been placed
on individual war graves. Before you left,
I pinned one onto your lapel, crimped petals,
spasms of paper red, disrupting a blockade
of yellow bias binding around your blazer.

Sellotape bandaged around my hand,
I rounded up as many white cat hairs
as I could, smoothed down your shirt's
upturned collar, steeled the softening
of my face. I wanted to graze my nose
across the tip of your nose, play at
being Eskimos like we did when
you were little. I resisted the impulse
to run my fingers through the gelled
blackthorns of your hair. All my words
flattened, rolled, turned into felt,

slowly melting. I was brave, as I walked
with you, to the front door, threw
it open, the world overflowing
like a treasure chest. A split second
and you were away, intoxicated.
After you'd gone I went into your bedroom,
released a song bird from its cage.
Later a single dove flew from the pear tree,
and this is where it has led me,
skirting the church yard walls, my stomach busy
making tucks, darts, pleats, hat-less, without
a winter coat or reinforcements of scarf, gloves.

On reaching the top of the hill I traced
the inscriptions on the war memorial,
leaned against it like a wishbone.
The dove pulled freely against the sky,
an ornamental stitch. I listened, hoping to hear
your playground voice catching on the wind.

Jane Weir

Symbolism *The poppy has symbolic links to violence, death and memory. It is quite foreboding in this poem.*

Pronouns *"I" and "Your" used to emphasises the intimacy and closely of the speaker and subject.*

Blockade *Military reference to blocking, perhaps of emotion.* ***Alliteration*** *also used with bias, binding, blunder emphasise bustle, mothering over her son.*

Familiar noun/military metaphor *The reference to sellotape is quite a familiar homely image, 'bandaged' can be used to imply wound or injury/harm.*

Sibilance, *The words 'steeled, shirt, softening' etc. gives a calm tone to the scene described in the poem.*

Aside, *the personal* ***anecdote*** *creates a sense of intimacy and human realism in the speakers voice.* ***Juxtaposed*** *with the military side of her son.*

Metaphor, *a reference to the shortened hair stubble required in the military and how aggressive it makes her son appear to her.*

Power of three*, reflects the way the mother is tongue tied and doesn't know what to say, she is proud of her son but also doesn't want him to go.*

Symbolic, *idea of throwing the door open and setting her son free. The door* ***represents*** *her own acceptance of his choice.*

Simile, *suggests how attractive the world appears to her son and also her aspiration for him to have opportunities.*

Metaphor, *connotes that he is like a beautiful caged creature and needs to be set free. Implies that she understands this includes free to make mistakes and be harmed.*

Vague Pronoun, *contains* ***double meaning****, this as in the location but also the situation, suggests that 'this' is her sons death, she cannot bear to speak the words. Implies pain.*

Listing, *implies the awkward feeling of the mother, trying to distract herself from grief.*

Physical senses, *implies the intimacy between mother and son,* ***connotes*** *the tactile hypersensitivity and jumbled emotions.*

Caesura, *breaking down the verses, implies the choking back tears.*

If you want to help your understanding you could:

-Look at the work and background of the Royal Legion and Poppy appeal, what impact have they had on people?

Context:

The poem looks at a mother of a son who has grown up and gone to war. The poem contains many clues that this is a more modern conflict, however the poem ends at the memorial, suggesting the son died at war or has at least not yet returned home and is now missed by the mother who fears the worst.

The poem is based very heavily around the idea of Poppies as memorials and therefore the idea of memory. The poem flashes back to key moments of the life of the mother and son.

The poem also contains a range of emotions. There is genuine sadness but also pride. The poem doesn't seem to comment heavily on the war itself.

Poppy appeal poppy badges

Themes:

The poem looks partially at conflict because of the nature of the son going to war, however it looks at conflict more from the perspective of those it leaves behind and the emotions of families. It is a behind the scenes view of conflict rather than addressing the conflict itself. There is also a level of conflict in the mothers emotions, pride, fear, sadness.

Structure: Written as a monologue in 4 stanzas and no rhyme scheme. The stanzas are structured along events in the life of mother and child. 1st the mother looks back at remembrance day and the idea of the poppy which has helped trigger the memory. 2nd the mother talks about helping her son get ready and seeing him off. 3rd the poem explores the emptiness that is left in his absence, finally the mother feels drawn to a war memorial bringing the story back to where it started, yet now with no son around. The suggestion of the dove being that he has died. The poem uses a lot of enjambment and familiar nouns to enhance the idea of natural tone and the mothers voice.

War and Peace:

There is a huge contrast with some of the imagery of the poem, sometimes linking to violence "blackthorns of your hair"/"Blockade" and the more peaceful homely images "released a song bird"/"play at being Eskimos". This contrast emphasises the conflicting emotions in the mother.

By the end of this you should know:

Higher Marks	Lower Marks
-The relationship in the poem provides a deeper level of empathy and the conflict between what was and what now is the relationship.	*-The poem looks at the relationship of Mother and Son.*
-The poem uses a range of devices to capture the speakers sad and reflective tone.	*-The poem uses very natural monologue style to give it a very easy to understand tone.*
-The poems uses contrasting language and ideas to emphasise the conflict and turmoil of the Mother.	*-The poem mixes language to do with war along with those that create a sense of home life.*

Space for your notes: